nature of relationship that Afghan groups enjoyed with Pakistan than the character and composition of the group itself. From this logic, non-engagement with even those Afghan political outfits that were indeed dependent on Pakistan was unviable. Isolating such groups would only increase their dependence on Pakistan (like the Taliban regime in the 1990s), and push them into a direct standoff with both the Afghan government as well as India. The realisation that most Afghans harbored goodwill for India, and even the Pakistan-dependent factions did not nurture ill will, helped in coming to terms with the possibility to cautiously reconcile with the Afghan Taliban.

Engaging with select Afghan Taliban factions, the conciliators argued, would reduce the risk of misunderstanding, help India secure its assets and interests in the region, and ensure that the Taliban does not become hostile to India. Additionally, India's conciliatory approach would help the Kabul government in its reconciliation (however unsuccessful) with the Afghan Taliban, and to exploit the political ruptures that were visible within the insurgent groups. True, given the tormented history of India's relations with the Taliban, any engagement whatsoever would be of a limited nature. But the costs of non-engagement were higher than those of engagement. While groups like the Haqqani network elicited unambiguous hostility from the partisans and the conciliators alike (for attacking the Indian embassy and consulates), the Quetta shura (and its sub-factions) were acceptable to engage with. Plus, all those Afghan Taliban figures that were ready to reconcile with the Kabul government could be engaged with. Such a nuanced and conciliatory approach, however, did not go unchallenged. The partisans continued advocating active containment of any and all militant factions along the Afghanistan-Pakistan border using force (in different forms) if necessary. For them, there was little difference between the various Taliban factions (both Afghan and Pakistani) and the only credible partners that India could have in Afghanistan were either the former United Front leaders or the Kabul government.

India's conciliatory outlook was in stark contrast with New Delhi's derision of Western categorisations such as 'good' and 'bad' Taliban (with the argument that all Taliban were unsavoury). At an operational level, indeed, Indian spies and diplomats in Afghanistan had begun engaging with the militant and political